English Studies

ISSN: 0013-838X (Print) 1744-4217 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/nest20

Masculinity, the Environment and the Phenomenology of the Body in *Beowulf*

Jacek Olesiejko

To cite this article: Jacek Olesiejko (14 Nov 2025): Masculinity, the Environment and the Phenomenology of the Body in *Beowulf*, English Studies, DOI: 10.1080/0013838X.2025.2585317

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/0013838X.2025.2585317

Published online: 14 Nov 2025.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 162

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=nest20

ENGLISH STUDIES
https://doi.org/10.1080/0013838X.2025.2585317

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

Masculinity, the Environment and the Phenomenology of the Body in *Beowulf*[1]

Jacek Olesiejko

Adam Mickiewicz University, Poznań, Poland

ABSTRACT
The present article advances an ecocritical and ecofeminist reading of masculinity in *Beowulf*. It argues that the representation of masculine embodiment and subjectivity is intricately entangled with the poem's representations of the environment, especially the bodies of water. The paper engages in a discussion with ecofeminism as well as with (eco)critical masculinity studies to elucidate the use of maritime imagery and landscape in *Beowulf* as a function of ideology.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 5 August 2024
Accepted 30 October 2025

KEYWORDS
Beowulf; old English poetry; medieval ecocriticism; masculinity studies; ecofeminism

> At the start of it all there is He: the classical ideal of 'Man', formulated first by Protagoras as 'the measure of all things', later renewed in the Italian Renaissance as a universal model and represented in Leonardo da Vinci's Vitruvian Man. An ideal of bodily perfection which, in keeping with the classical dictum *mens sansa in corpore sano,*doubles up as a set of mental, discursive and spiritual values. Together they uphold a specific view of what is 'human' about humanity.[2]

Introduction: Heorot in Crisis

In *Beowulf*, Hrothgar's reign is presented as a continuation of Scyld Scefing's legacy. His own achievements earlier in his life have resulted not only in the further consolidation of the Scyldings' rule over the region[3] but also in the building and establishment of Heorot as the major symbol of the dynastic glory and power in the poem's world. Hrothgar's reign in the poem's narrative is, however, also riddled with a number of crises. Grendel's attack on his kingdom is a major reversal that ends the glorious part of his reign. This attack has often been read accordingly as a symbol representing human and political issues affecting the Danes as a people,[4] Hrothgar's warrior-band and the ruling family.

CONTACT Jacek Olesiejko olesiejk@amu.edu.pl

[1]All quotations from *Beowulf* come from Klaeber IV. Translations are mine. The vocabulary I use is largely based on Klaeber's glossary updated, where possible, with the help of the online Toronto Dictionary of Old English A-Le. Klaeber's glossary has been critically discussed in Bloomfield, "Diminished by Kindness", for its misrepresentation of gender and agency, especially in relation to Wealhtheow's speeches.

[2]Rosi Braidotti, *The Posthuman,* 13.

[3]As lines 4–11 indicate, Scyld becomes something of an overlord over other kingdoms in the area. Other lords ('eorlas') pay tribute to the Danes.

[4]On Grendel as an inversion of human and heroic norms see Dubois, "The Unity of *Beowulf*".

© 2025 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Hrothgar's sorrow[5] sets the emotional tone for the poem's account of these crises. Even though Beowulf comes as a saviour, his ensuing success creates another crisis. Now, as Beowulf has defeated Grendel, Hrothgar offers the young hero the throne,[6] a move that might cause an internal conflict over succession in Denmark.[7] Crises also beset some other characters, for example, Unferth, and presumably many other lesser-nameless Danish warriors whose inability to handle *Grendles þing* (the Grendel affair) (l. 409b) has undermined both their own heroic identities and Hrothgar's worthiness as a Scylding successor.

King Hrothgar, who suffers crises of identity and self-definition, is ostensibly praised as the greatest king *be sæm tweonum* (between two seas).[8] His retinue of Danish warriors is incapable of bringing a solution to the crisis effected by Grendel's raids. The poem is also a crisis narrative of Beowulf's self-definition as a promising prince, worthy of a kingdom.[9] That he alone is able to probe the depths of seas, fight sea-monsters and dive into Grendel's mother's mere intensifies the crisis of both succession and heroic identity at Heorot. It would appear that the tension, which I argue lies at the centre of the poem's narrative and thought, between Beowulf as an accomplished swimmer, who defeats underwater monsters and becomes throne-worthy, and Hrothgar, the king "between two seas", is never quite resolved in the poem. The maritime aesthetics of the poem's imagery may thus be probed for the role in the poem's narrative.[10]

The present paper will advance an ecocritical examination of *Beowulf*'s representation of masculinity and power and will interrogate the representation of the sea in *Beowulf* as well as the poem's investigation of men's minds and bodies. I argue that *Beowulf* represents the natural environment through malestream norms, borrowing the term malestream from Mary O'Brien's *Politics of Reproduction*.[11] I thus align my reading of *Beowulf* more broadly with ecofeminism and environmental masculinity studies. In *Beowulf*, the masculine body is marshalled in the poem to validate the dominant perspective from which to perceive and experience the world, creating a malestream phenomenology of masculine subjectivity as the norm of the human presence in the human and nonhuman world. The epigraph from Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* guides the paper's argument, highlighting a distant, but provocatively resonant, kinship between the classical humanist assumption that the male and the masculine embody norms of representation and the poem's male-appropriated representation of the environment. The later sections, given to the analysis of Beowulf's sojourn at Hrothgar's Heorot, will investigate the role of

[5]Lines 190–4.

[6]Lines 946b–956.

[7]On succession in *Beowulf* see Brodeur, *The Art of Beowulf*; Leneghan, *The Dynastic Drama*; Olesiejko, "The Grendelkin and the Politics of Succession". Wealhtheow speeches, one directed at Hrothgar, another at Beowulf, have been extensively commented upon and argued to be an intervention into Hrothgar's offer of throne extended to Beowulf. These speeches have been discussed often. For references see Conrad O'Brian "Listen to the Woman", especially 92–94.

[8]The expression appears three times in *Beowulf*. At line 858b it refers to Beowulf fame that spreads after he defeats Grendel. At line 1297 it refers to Æschere. At line 1685 it refers to Hrothgar. See Howe, *Migration and Mythmaking*, for his discussion of the formula as "a geographical measure of fame", 157. Beowulf's fame after he defeats Grendel also spreads 'be sæm tweonum' (858b). Howe, however, claims that "the phrase denotes the geography of the north and stresses its cultural uniformity", 157. I suggest that in *Beowulf* the phrase might be an expression that connotes overlordship achieved through conquest or subjugation.

[9]Lines 856b–861.

[10]Larry D. Benson claims that the oldest element in the poem related to the protagonist is the account of Beowulf as an accomplished swimmer, "The originality of *Beowulf*", 1–43. This theory is further elaborated in Leneghan, *The Dynastic drama of Beowulf*, 118–21.

[11]O'Brien, *Politics of Reproduction*, 62.

water bodies in an account of the construction of heroic masculinity and masculine royal power, focusing on Beowulf and Hrothgar.

Beowulf's Malestream Phenomenal Diction: Seas and Selves

In the Old English Exeter Book, the didactic poem known under the modern editorial title *Maxims I,* juxtaposes the minds of rulers with the stormy sea.

Styran sceal mon strongum mode.
geofen in grimmum sælum;
fealwe on feorran to londe,
Weallas him wiþre healdað,
Swa biþ sæ smilte,
swa beoþ þeoda geþwære,
gesittað him on gesundum þingum,
cene men gecynde rice.

Storm oft holm gebringeþ,
onginnað grome fundian, h
hwæþer he fæste stonde.
him biþ wind gemæne.
þonne hy wind ne weceð;
þonne hy geþingad habbað,
ond þonne mid gesiþum healdaþ

> One must steer with a strong mind. Storm often brings the sea, the ocean, into severe condition; angry, fallow waves from afar begin rushing to land, testing whether or not it will stand firm. Walls hold out against them, wind is common to both. As the sea is calm when it does not awaken its waters, so people are peaceful when they come to agreement; they sit in prosperity, and then brave men with their companions control the lawful kingdom (50-57a).[12]

The passage presupposes juxtaposing the fierceness of the sea with the ordered human world. The representations of the violent sea in *Beowulf* might be thus viewed as a poetic device that holds up a mirror to the heroic disposition that, appraised positively as it is, can also be potentially destructive. Just as the stormy sea encroaches on land, so does anger disrupt social order. The storm and human anger are thus represented as best to exist as external to, respectively, land and society. Importantly, the sea, by way of personification, displays cognitive attributes. The verb *fundian* suggests inquisitiveness. The phrase *hwæþer he fæste stonde* (whether or not it will stand firm) intimates that the sea constantly tries to test the firmness of land.[13] Jennifer Neville observes in her *Representations of the Natural World in Old English Poetry* that the environment in Old English poetry is depicted as antagonistic to humanity. Such representations, as she claims, serve to expose the fragility of the human cultural world.[14] This passage intimates yet another danger: "the natural world symbolises the forces – here human conflict – capable of destroying society".[15]

The passage establishes an isomorphism between the sea and the human mind.[16] In *Beowulf,* too, there is an intriguing parallel between minds entangled in crisis and turbulent bodies of water. It might appear that the poem suggests that the audience imagine

[12]The Old English text and translation come from Bjork, *Old English Shorter Poems*.

[13]This point is made by Harriet Soper, where she identifies a contrast between the firm land and investigative sea in *Maxims I*, *Life-Course,* 72.

[14]Jennifer Neville stresses that most Old English verse represents humanity as powerless against forces of nature. See Neville, *Representations of the Natural World,* 21–22.

[15]Neville provides an interesting historicising interpretation of the passage in the context of Anglo-Danish treaties: "the passage in *Maxims I* suggests how agreements and rulers could be seen as comforting and necessary defence against a political uncertainty as frightening and devastating as the ocean", *Representations*, 55.

[16]Harriet Soper utilises the concept of isomorphism in her discussion of the Exeter Book Riddles, which "suggest experience shared between the lives of humans, animals, plants, things, and the cosmos, without necessarily insinuating

anxious men and the rough sea as a single isomorphic body, whose angry waves surge and subside, providing a similar pattern to human and non-human lives, history, and the environment. For example, when Hrothgar faces Æschere's death at the hands of Grendel's mother, he is *on hreon mode* (his mind is in distress) (l. 1307b). Earlier, when Beowulf describes his swimming match with Breca and the stormy sea, he says, *hreo wæron yþa* (the waves were turbulent) (l. 548b).[17] Such an isomorphism is explored by Gillian R. Overing in her essay on men *Beowulf,* "Men in Trouble", where she argues that in such Old English poems as *Beowulf* and "The Wanderer" there is "an isomorphic relation between self and world" and that "affect is understood via mind in connection with body, in dynamic relation with cultural and physical worlds".[18] In her essay, she mostly considers the double context for the use of the adjective *hreo,* which can refer both to mental disturbance as well as turbulent weather.[19] She suggests that in *Beowulf* "the storm is one of inner conflict, confusion, turmoil, or anxiety, a symptom of a self in crisis".[20]

In light of the recent work done on mentality and emotion in Old English verse, it must be added, however, that in *Beowulf,* such representations of mentality and emotion are also pervasively aligned with the cardiocentric model of emotion as a mental swelling.[21] Beowulf comes to Hrothgar because his wish is that the king's *cearwylmas colran wurðaþ* (seethings of sorrow will become cold) (l. 282). Other characters in the poem experience *sorhwylmas,* (surges of sorrow) (l. 904b), *breostwylm* (surging of the breast) (Hrothgar's intense sorrow when Beowulf departs, l. 1877a). What is particularly interesting from an ecocritical perspective on affect is that this psychologising language is paralleled in the poem by references to literal storms and seas. The simplex *wylm* (welling, surging) (l. 516a) as well as such phrases as *wæateres wylm* (surging of water) (l. 1693a), *flodes wylm* (flood) (l. 1764), and *holmwylm* (surge of the sea, sea-current) (l. 2411) refer to the rough sea in *Beowulf.* The emotional word *cearwylm* (seething of sorrow) is similar in structure to such compounds as *sæwylm* (sea-welling, billow) (l. 393b) *brimwylm* (surge of the sea) (l. 1494). At another point, Hygelac tells Beowulf: *Ic ðæs modceare sorhwylmum seað, siðe ne truwode leofes mannes* (I seethed with waves of care on account of my soul's sorrow, I did not feel certain about the outcome of the dear man's journey) (l. 1992-1993). Beowulf speculates about Ingeld's violence that will arise, *syððan Ingelde weallað wælniðas, ond him wiflufan æfter cearwælmum colran weorðað* (when deadly hate swells in Ingeld and his love for the wife becomes colder after the seething of his sorrow) (l. 2064-2066).

The poem's investment in the representations of entanglements of subjectivity with the world, especially through its attention to an isomorphic extension between men's embodied minds and bodies of water, suggests that its perspective on the world is phenomenological. Phenomenology elucidates the embodiment and material embeddedness of human experience, always reconstituted by the material world that pre-exists the

these are wholly imported or projected from the human realm", *Life-Course*, 9. She prefers the term over anthropomorphism, *Life-Course*, 9.

[17]The Toronto Dictionary of Old English lists "turbulent, fierce, cruel" as the primary meaning of hrēoh, rēow.

[18]Overing, "Men in Trouble", 29.

[19]Ibid., 31–32.

[20]Ibid., 31.

[21]Mental welling of emotional fluid is also related to what is identified as the hydraulic model of the mind discussed in Lockett, *Vernacular Psychologies,* 5. She provides a substantial discussion of Old English poetic vocabulary related to such mental swelling, especially verbs *weallan* and *belgan* in *Vernacular Psychologies,* 50.

experiencing subject. Maurice Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology, especially as developed in his *Phenomenology of Perception*, has already been productively applied by Daniel C. Remein's reading of *Beowulf*, in which he argues that the *Beowulf* poet develops a pervasive phenomenological poetics.[22] Merleau-Ponty presents perception and embodiment as processes that involve embodied humans and their environment as interacting partners. For instance, Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* understands sensations as transcendental events in pre-personal and phenomenological fields. The world, for Merleau-Ponty, is not an object, but a field of experience actively constituting the human subject: "the world is inseparable from the subject, but from a subject that is nothing but a project of the world".[23]

Remein suggests some important implications that this phenomenal reading has for ecocritical studies of the poem. For example, he argues that "this phenomenological tangle, as a function poem's sensological relationship to the non-human world, would precipitate a profoundly ecopoetical moment".[24] Remein's observation is potentially inspirational for understanding *Beowulf* as ecopoetry.[25] When approached through the lens of ecocriticism, *Beowulf*'s phenomenological poetry is problematic, however, as such potentially ecopoetic moments are compromised by the poem's malestream representation of the environment. Firstly, *Beowulf* is a profoundly ideological poem in that it is pervasively invested in the production of the masculine subject as well as a complex phenomenology of the male hero's experience.[26] Secondly, the poem is more interested in establishing rather than revising the boundaries between the human and nonhuman. The poem's ideological investment in the poem's representation of landscape and seascape has been discussed by Alfred K. Siewers through the lens of ecocritical and postcolonial theory.[27] Nicole Guenther Discenza argues along similar lines that "Grendel and his mother cross from their own waste, wild space into what had been ordered, civilized space, bringing chaos and destruction into the Danes's world".[28] As Christopher Abram observes in his analysis of the fens in the poem, *Beowulf* "is written from and for the point of view of the 'civilized' [audience]".[29] Thirdly, especially in the episode that narrates Beowulf's combat with Grendel's mother, the poem's narrative creates a masculine subjectivity by testing it against Grendel's mother's subjectivity. The poem's account of Beowulf's attack on Grendel's mother's mere is problematic in terms of the representation of gender and race.[30] In that narrative, Beowulf emerges as a masculine

[22]Remein, *The Heat of Beowulf*, especially 93–100. Also, David Buchanan's unpublished PhD dissertation, *Phenomenal Anglo-Saxons: Perception, Adaptation, and the Poetic Imagination*, uses phenomenology to elucidates the strategies of translation employed by Old English poets in the process of translating Latin literature into Old English Verse.

[23]Merleau-Ponty, *Phenomenology of Perception*, 454. The concept of the phenomenal field is used throughout *Phenomenology of Experience*, especially 224–5 and 426–9.

[24]Remein, *The Heat of Beowulf*, 92.

[25]The concept of ecopoetry is defined by J.Scott Bryson in *Ecopoetry: A Critical Introduction.*: "Ecopoetry is a mode that, while adhering to certain conventions of traditional poetry, advances beyond that tradition and takes on distinctly contemporary problems and issues, thus becoming generally marked by three primary characteristics: an ecological and biocentric perspective reorganizing the inter dependent nature of the world; a deep humility with regard to our relationships with human and nonhuman nature; and an intense scepticism toward hyperrationality a scepticism that leads to an indictment of an overtechnologized modern world and a warning concerning the very real potential for ecological catastrophe". 5–6. Matt Low applies this definition in article on Old English elegies, "Ecopoetry", 16.

[26]See Price, "Sufficient Tragedy", 682–3, for an account of secondary literature on masculinity in *Beowulf*.

[27]Siewers, *Landscapes of Conversion*.

[28]Discenza, *Inhabited Spaces*, 146.

[29]Abram, "At Home in the Fens", 138.

[30]See Kim, "The Question of Race"; Morrison, "Grendel and his Mother", 260–1.

self more deeply embedded in masculine heroic culture,[31] while incrementally demoting Grendel's mother from a queen, as well as a caring, vengeful, and unequivocally heroic mother, until she disappears both literally and symbolically.[32]

Such representations merit a thorough discussion in light of the ecofeminist philosophy and ecocritical masculinity studies to investigate the extent to which *Beowulf* privileges the anthropocentric and androcentric vantage point from which the culture/nature divide in the poem is constructed and represented. Ecofeminist thought supplies critical tools for interrogating the role of the poem's phenomenal diction in the generation of the poem's male heroic discourse.[33] For example, ecofeminists have critiqued the western notion of reason/nature binary, which results in the hyper-separation of the human from the nonhuman world as well as, in Val Plumwood's words, "the convergence of the concepts of the human and the masculine".[34] Rosi Braidotti critiques such androcentrism and anthropocentrism by critically addressing the humanist concept of the universal man.[35] In addition, ecofeminism readily perceives the world as a more-than-human and interspecies community, often pinpointing the androcentrism informing notions of human exceptionalism. For instance, the ecofeminist scholar and activist Greta Gaard discusses the androcentric character of the Anthropocene in her account of the instrumental use of animals in extra-terrestrial exploration.[36] Marti Kheel argues that masculinism "idealises transcending the biological realm, as represented by other-than-human animals and affiliative ties".[37] Another important field, aligned with ecofeminism, is ecological masculinities.[38] In their *Ecological Masculinities,* Martin Hultman and Paul M. Pulé utilise Mary O'Brien's concept of malestream norms to "highlight the ways masculinities manifest in private and public as well as personal and professional spheres, effectively normalising masculine hegemonisation".[39]

Early medieval English literature has also been subject to ecofeminist criticism.[40] It is thus pertinent to question the poem's malestream diction to investigate the poem's interest in masculine subjectivity with a view to reconsidering the poem's dominant perspective and revealing non-masculine and more-than-human vantage points at the poem's

[31]It is notable that while Beowulf approaches Grendel on equal footing by refusing to bear weapons to fight the opponent who refrains using a sword, he plunges into Grendel's mother's mere fully armed. In addition, only using another sword after the first weapon has failed him does he manage to kill her. In the combat with Grendel's mother Beowulf is attributed more human and fewer monstrous features.

[32]Oswald, *Monsters, Gender, and Sexuality,* 95–96.

[33]Other important books in the field of ecofeminism include Merchant, *The Death of Nature*; Plumwood, *Feminism and the Mastery of Nature*.

[34]Plumwood, *Feminism and the Mastery*, 25. For the concept of hyperseparation, which is also termed radical exclusion, see Plumwood, *Environmental Culture*, 101–3. The Western objectification of nature and women in antiquity and modernity is discussed in Merchant, *The Death of Nature.*

[35]See, *The Posthuman*, 65, and, more recent, *Posthuman Feminism*, 68–104.

[36]Gaard, *Critical Ecofeminism*, 92–114.

[37]Kheel, *Nature Ethics*, 3. See also Donna J. Haraway, who introduces the concept of the Chthulucene as an alternative to the Anthropocene to counter the Western notions of human exceptionalism and integrate an interspecies perspective of the more-than-human world into her philosophical outlook.

[38]See especially See Hultman and Pulé's *Ecological Masculinities,* where they advance the practice of caring masculinity "for the intersecting terrain between modern Western men, masculinities, and earth", 2. Their another, more recent volume, *Men, Masculinity, and Earth.*

[39]Hultman and Pulé, *Ecological Masculinities,* 3.

[40]See Estes, *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscapes*, especially 24–25 and 147–9 for several important application of ecofeminist thought to Old English verse. There is also a recent ecofeminist reading of the Old English *Wife's Lament* by the indigenous scholar Andrews, "Research, Renewal". In their recent publications on Old English verse, Corinne Dale and Courtney Catherine Barajas question the assumption that medieval literature is anthropocentric.

margins. Here, I would like to create a common space for ecofeminist and critical masculinity studies to examine several episodes in *Beowulf* in which bodies of water serve to establish the man as subject and agent. Building from the ecofeminist premise that the masculine gaze constitutes and projects on the environment a subject/object binary, it will be argued here that the poem's representations of the sea invest military masculinity with a set of heroic roles that define men as subjects and agents. In addition, these representations forge a vital association of kingship and land, defining humanmade space as a dominion to be enclosed and protected from a hostile external other.

Beowulf's Sea-Voyage

The environment in *Beowulf* is a source of both aesthetic pleasure and anxiety. Both pleasure and anxiety presuppose a perspective relatable to an early English male aristocratic reader. Beowulf's travel to and arrival at Heorot represent an ecology between humans and the environment in which human-made objects are instrumental for humans to negotiate as well as relate to the environment. In her ecocritical discussion of sea-crossing in *Elene, Andreas, Exodus* and *Beowulf,* Heide Estes claims that such episodes induce "pleasure in the environment" and reveal the human confidence that the ship can defy the dangers of the waters.[41] The account of Beowulf's passage across the sea to meet Hrothgar concentrates on the ship that is described with terms that range from a travelling companion to a physical tool. Its language, most importantly, represents the ship as an agential force and as capable of being both subject and object.

godne gegyrwan,
ofer swanrade
mærne þeoden,
ðone siðfæt him
lythwon logon,
hwetton higerofne,
Hæfde se goda
cempan gecorone
findan mihte;
sundwudu sohte;
lagucræftig mon,
Fyrst forð gewat.
bat under beorge.
on stefn stigon;
sund wið sande;
on bearm nacan
guðsearo geatolic;
weras on wilsið,
Gewat þa ofer wægholm,
flota famiheals
oðþæt ymb antid
wundenstefna
þæt ða liðende
brimclifu blican,
side sænæssas;
eoletes æt ende.

Het him yðlidan
cwæð, he guðcyning
secean wolde,
þa him wæs manna þearf.
snotere ceorlas
þeah he him leof wære;
hæl sceawedon.
Geata leoda
þara þe he cenoste
XVna sum
secg wisade,
landgemyrcu.
Flota wæs on yðum,
Beornas gearwe
streamas wundon,
secgas bæron
beorhte frætwe,
guman ut scufon,
wudu bundenne.
winde gefysed,
fugle gelicost,
oþres dogores
gewaden hæfde
land gesawon,
beorgas steape,
þa wæs sund liden,
þanon up hraðe

[41]Estes, *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscapes,* 37. Estes points out the ecocritical position on such depictions obscure the practices of exploitation of the sea, although it has to be admitted that Anglo-Saxons did not exert as negative an impact on the sea as our contemporaries, *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscapes,* 38.

Wedera leode on wang stigon,
sæwudu sældon (syrcan hrysedon,
guðgewædo), gode þancedon
þæs þe him yþlade eaðe wurdon

> He told them to prepare a good wave-traverser, saying that he wanted to visit that war-king across the swan-road, that renowned prince, who was in need of men. Little did wisemen blame him for the voyage even though he was dear to them. They encouraged the valiant man and drew lots. The good leader of the Geats selected the best from among the choicest of men available to him. Fifteen of them sought the see-wood. The man led the way, an experienced sailor, towards the boundary of the region. Time went forth. The ship was on the waves, the boat under the cliff. The warriors came readily aboard the vessel. Currents mingled water with sand; the men placed bright accoutrements in the bosom of the ship, splendid armour. They moved the bound wood forward, willingly engaging in the enterprise. The foamy flier departed not unlike a bird and went on to cross the ocean of waves, pushed by the wind. Finally, by the end of the other day the ship with a bound prow advanced to a point where the sailors saw land and cliff shining, steep mountains, broad promontories. The voyage was over. The Geats readily disembarked upon the shore and moored the sea-wood (their armour and war-garment rattled) and thanked God for the safe passage across the sea (ll. 198b-228).

The pleasure created by the text lies in the representations of a potentially hostile environment as serving human purposes. I would add that the ship is an assemblage that absorbs some features of two kinds of spaces that remain external to the human world and yet are also essential to its construction and flourishing: the forest and the sea. Since wood is the material cause of the ship. Synecdochically, the ship continues to constitute part of a forest, which is a standing reserve for shipbuilding. The passage is rich in kennings and compounds that describe the ship in terms of its building material. The kenning *sund-wudu* (sea-wood) (l. 208a) concentrates on the material and the maritime context of its use. The compound *wudu-bundene* (bound wood) (l. 216b), also referring to the ship, reinforces the poem's idea of human ability to shape hard material into objects that serve human purposes.

The passage might be read as an ecopoetic moment in which the sea is viewed from a nonhuman perspective. In his detailed analysis of it, Remein concludes that, as a setting, the sea "[disturbs] the representational process of the poem",[42] the process which aims at the characterisation of human heroic action.[43] Remein develops Peter Clemoes's argument that the passage in question represents a dynamic interaction between space and the human-made object.[44] Heide Estes's statement that the sea in Old English verse "is not simply a static stage for human actions, but a very strong presence, interacting with, influencing, and affecting the human characters"[45] also emphasises the ability of Old English poets to transcend anthropocentrism in their maritime poetry. Remein similarly suggests a more-than-human perspective presupposed in the passage, as he argues

[42]Remein, "The Heat", 212.
[43]Ibid., 208.
[44]As Clemoes observes, "that this interaction is organic is borne out by the vocabulary: the sea is at first waves, then currents with depth, and finally a *wægholm*, a whole sea of waves; the boat changes from a utilitarian thing of specific parts, a prow and a hold, to a whole object designed to with stand the sea, *wudu bundenne* (a ship with a bound prow), and finally becomes a thing of pure movement, a foamy-necked floater like a bird. Both boat and sea undergo development within their distinctive beings". See: Clemoes, "Action in *Beowulf*", 152.
[45]Estes, *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscapes*, 35–36.

that it is characterised by the poem's "non-representational horizon and an ecopoetical trajectory".[46]

I would suggest, however, that the narrative closeness to the account of the horrors besetting Heorot heightens an androcentric perspective that pervades the passage. Estes's statement that such representations offer pleasure to the reader is thus insightful. Insofar as it provides a relief from the horrors that the Danes are experiencing at Heorot, the passage is reassuring for the reader. In addition, Clemoes points out that the voyage "is a qualitative development by which the uncomplicated action of the ship is replaced by, issues in, makes directly possible, another, fuller, more significant action by the men".[47] The sea-crossing, like the building of Heorot, is therefore a context for a construction of masculine authority. As Hrothgar ordered Heorot to be built (*hatan wolde*, l. 68b), Beowulf ordered his men (*het him*, l. 198b) to prepare the ship for the voyage. It is thus notable that the passage intimates that Hrothgar lacks men, *him wæs manna þearf* (Hrothgar was in need of men) (l. 201b). As human-made objects, Beowulf's ship and Hrothgar's Heorot diverge in enhancing contrasting emotions of pleasure and anxiety. Beowulf's ship illustrates the success of human attempts to command the environment.

The Sea in the Breca Episode

Heorot has a complicated relationship with the wilderness of the moors inhabited by Grendel and his mother.[48] Rather than a place productive of pleasure, with a view to counterbalancing the pleasure derived from Beowulf's safe sea-crossing, Heorot becomes a place of violent death inflicted on male bodies, an object that generates masculine anxiety over heroic identity. When Beowulf arrives at Heorot, Hrothgar himself gives a poignant account of his men's failed attempts to defeat Grendel after they ritually promised victory over a ceremonial mead-cup. This point validates the poet's intimation, parenthetically articulated during the account of Beowulf's sea-crossing, that *him wæs manna þearf* (Hrothgar was in need of men) (l. 201b).

Ful oft gebeotedon	beore druncne
ofer ealo-wæge	oret-mecgas
þæt hie in beor-sele	bidan woldon
Grendles guþe	mid gryrum ecga.
Ðonne wæs þeos medoheal	on morgentid,
driht-sele dreor-fah,	þonne dæg lixte,
eal benсþelu	blode bestymed,
heall heorudreore;	ahte ic holdra þy læs,
deorre duguðe,	þe þa deað fornam.
Site nu to symle	ond onsæl meoto,oe
sigehreð secgum,	swa þin sefa hwette

Drunken with beer, warriors often vowed over cups of ale that they would brace themselves for Grendel's violence and await him with edges of their swords in the beer-hall. Then that

[46]Remein, *The Heat of Beowulf*, 200.
[47]Clemoes, "Action in *Beowulf*", 158.
[48]As Christopher Abram argues, for example, the intention to demarcate the humanmade space against the fens is challenged internally within the poem. He reads Heorot as "something alien, something out of place" and points out that "Heorot is, presumably, built on the edge of the fen" and that "the two locations [that is, Heorot and Grendel's mere] are part of the same landscape". See: Abram, "At home in the Fens", 133–4.

> noble mead-hall was blood-stained in the morning. When the light of day appeared, all bench-plans were wet with battle-blood, the hall reddened with swords; I had fewer dear men in my loyal retinue when death took them. Now take your seat and take part in the feast and disclose your counsel, victorious glory to men as you mind dictates (ll. 480-490).

As Hugh Magennis argues, in Old English verse "feasting expresses metonymically the theme of life in the hall and in doing so it provides one of the most familiar and suggestive bodies of imagery".[49] In this passage, the connection between drinking and life is turned upside-down, however. In bitterly ironic terms, Grendel's decimation and dismemberment of Hrothgar's retinue represents a horrific reversal of consumption as social practice. The use b-alliteration conflates the imagery of ceremonial bear-drinking with bloodshed (*bencþelu blode*, l. 846). There are also words that sustain a graphic image of Heorot as stained with blood and gore: *driht-sele dreor-fah* (the hall was stained with gore) (l. 485a), *blode bestymed* (wet with blood) (l. 486b), *heall heorudreore* (the hall reddened with swords) (l. 487a). The passage artfully exposes the instability of the symbolic mode that underlies the poem's representation of heroic culture. While in Old English verse the cup is a symbol of normative and human consumption, Hrothgar's description conflates drink and bodily fluids.

The anxiety that informs Hrothgar's description of the present state of affairs at Heorot immediately finds another expression in Unferth's questioning of Beowulf's heroic prowess when he tries to shame the hero by claiming that he once lost a swimming contest. Not only does he claim that Beowulf lost the match, but also that Beowulf was, in the first place, reckless to participate in it.[50] Unferth is an important voice at Heorot. The role of *þyle*, which is attributed to Unferth in Hrothgar's court, is difficult to define precisely and might range from the counsellor and spokesman to jester.[51] This difficulty is coupled by the ambiguous appraisal of Unferth's heroism (as the poet attributes to Unferth jealousy of Beowulf's heroism[52] and points to his cowardly unwillingness to fight Grendel[53]) as well as his role in the history of Hrothgar's royal house (the killing of his brothers[54] and the intimation that he would be involved in the future conflict between Hrothulf and Hrothgar's sons).[55] It has nonetheless been suggested that the position of *þyle* was rather elevated. Carol J. Clover claims that one of the duties of *þyle* might include "the hostile investigation into the reputation of a newcomer".[56] Michael J. Enright draws upon Old Norse literature, in which "the *þulr* was a kind of orator with

[49]Magennis, *Images of Community*, 43.
[50](ll. 508–510a).
[51]Unferth is referred to as *þyle* twice in the poem: at lines 1165 and 1456. Editors of *Klaeber's Beowulf*, IV edition, gloss it as "orator, spokesman, official entertainer", *Klaeber's Beowulf*, 448. The Dictionary of Bosworth and Toller translates the word as "an orator, spokesman". The idea that the word means a jester was developed by Eliason, "The þyle and the Scop"; Robinson, "Elements of the Marvellous".
[52]Unferth's jealousy can be construed in different ways. While Robinson, "Elements of the Marvelous", 86–91. 129, considers him to be an unheroic and Falstaffian figure, it has also been suggested by critics who view Unferth as an established member of Hrothgar's *comitatus* that the feeling of jealousy comes from Unferth's fear that his own heroic deeds might be diminished by Beowulf's success. See Neidorf, "Unferth's Ambiguity", especially 451–3; Neidorf, "On *Beowulf* and the *Nibelungslied*", 664, for such a positive appraisal of Unferth. Unferth's jealousy is also addressed in Price, "Sufficient Tragedy", 685–9.
[53]Beowulf points out that Unferth has never dared to fight Grendel. The poet also states later that Unferth did not dare to fight Grendel's mother (lines 1468b–1471a).
[54]Beowulf refers to Unferth's fratricide (lines 587–9). The claim is validated later by the narrator (lines 1167b–1168).
[55]Lines 1162–8 suggest such an interpretation of future events at Heorot. See Fulk (et al.), *Beowulf*, 117, for a critical account of such interpretations.
[56]Clover, "The Germanic Context", 146.

a special seat in the hall and connection to a king", and further argues for the important place that Unferth occupies in Hrothgar's warband.[57]

It can be surmised that it is expected of Unferth to defend the honour of the Danes and question any newcomer warrior whose heroism might diminish the manhood of the Danish warriors.[58] In both Unferth's insulting speech and Beowulf's reply, the sea is important as a setting for masculine action as well as a symbolic referent for an examination of heroic masculinity. As a *þyle,* Unferth addresses the newcomer Beowulf as a rival for the comitatus of the Danish warriors. He evokes the maritime setting of the match to describe a possible deficiency in Beowulf's character.

> Git for wlence wada cunnedon
> ond for dolgilpe on deop wæter
> aldrum neþdon

> you tried the deep waters for pride and out of foolishness, risking your lives (ll. 508-510a)

To illustrate this deficiency, Unferth frames the famed story of Beowulf and Breca's swimming match in a contest of natural elements: *geofon yþum weol, /wintrys wylmum* (the ocean seethed with waves, the surging of winter) (ll. 515b-516a). His words suggest an isomorphism of the sea and human affects. Unferth's framing of such an isomorphism, however, implies a censure of the hero's desire to assert his masculine strength over elements and over another man as reckless. Unferth thus uses the sea to imply that Beowulf failed to endorse a truly heroic ideal of masculinity that combines the strength of the body with the strength of the mind.

Beowulf's version seems to reinvent his opponent's account not only by endowing the sea with more life and agency but also by interlacing human and nonhuman agencies.

> ða wit ætsomne
> fif nihta fyrst,
> wado weallende,
> nipende niht,
> heaðogrim ondhwearf;
> Wæs merefixa
> on sæ wæron
> oþþæt unc flod todraf,
> wedera cealdost,
> ond norþanwind
> hreo wæron yþa.
> mod onhrered;

> We had been together in the sea for five nights until the current, welling waves, the coldest weather, dark night, and the battle-grim north wind set as apart; the waves were angry, the minds of the sea-fish were disturbed (ll. 544-549).

When Beowulf fights against sea-monsters in his account of his swimming match with Breca, the waves are *hreo* (ferocious, angry) (l. 548b), a word that has a human referent elsewhere in the poem (l. 1307b). The anger of the sea reflects the hostility of sea-beasts: *wæs mere-fixa mod onhrered* (the courage, literally, also minds, of the fish was whetted) (l. 549). Both accounts characterise the sea and sea creatures as driven by affects mirroring human emotions and mentalities. However, before Beowulf gives his own version, he insists that his *merestrengo* (sea-strength) (533a) was greater than any other man's.

[57]Enright, "The Warband Context", 299–300.

[58]As Basil Arnould Price observes in his study of masculinity in *Beowulf*, "Heorot, the hall of Hroðgar, is a homosocial context that provides a setting for men to secure their masculinity by competing with and dominating one another in social, martial, and economic competitions". See: Price, "Sufficient Tragedy", 685.

Beowulf's maritime poetics are thus framed by his desire to assert his superior status as man and warrior.[59] Unferth the *þyle* implies that wisdom is the chief component of a heroic mental frame. Beowulf counters him by driving home the reality of physical perils circumscribing the courtly values which Unferth implies to lie at the heart of the heroic ideal. Beowulf's evocation of the sea's ferocity thus emphasises the need for the hero to embrace and control a corresponding ferocity within himself as an ideal of heroic self-mastery.

In addition, Beowulf adduces his sea-adventure to mediate the present crisis at Heorot through the use of humour. He says, for example, that he served the sea-monsters with his precious sword. Beowulf gives some force to the symbolism enacted by the social practice taking place at the feast.

Swa mec gelome laðgeteonan
þreatedon þearle. Ic him þenode
deoran sweorde, swa hit gedefe wæs.
Næs hie ðære fylle gefean hæfdon,
manfordædlan, þæt hie me þegon,
symbel ymbsæton sægrunde neah;
ac on mergenne mecum wundea
be yðlafe uppe lægon,
sweordum aswefede, þæt syðþan na
ymb brontne ford brimliðende
lade ne letton.

> The foes frequently threatened me severely. I served them a costly sword, as was fit. The malefactors did not take pleasure in the feast, as they failed to make a meal of me at their table at the bottom of the sea; but in the morning, wounded with the sword, on the shore they lay put to sleep with the heirloom, so they could not obstruct sailors on the deep water-way (ll. 559-569a).

Beowulf's humorous use of *fylle* (feast) (l. 562) alludes to Grendel's "wælfylle" (abundance of the slain) (l. 125a) of the bodies of Hrothgar's men that he carried from Heorot. His statement that he served the sea-monsters (*þenode*, l. 560b) may humorously allude to the male attendant serving drinks earlier (ll. 491-498). His grim joke offers an account of a combat in which human objects can successfully operate within the symbolic and ideological mode of the language of feasting and bear-drinking. The bed of the sea is described by Beowulf as a parody of the hall-floor on which retainers sit around and enjoy a banquet. The beasts ended up being killed by Beowulf, and in the morning their corpses lay asleep on the seashore, an image that is also a humorous reversal of the Danes asleep after a feast at the moment of Grendel's first attack: the Danes *swefan æfter symble* (slumbered after the feast) (l. 119a). Beowulf's reply to Unferth's investigation is an act of translation that constructs a maritime setting for masculine endeavour. The sea that Unferth represents in his version of the account becomes, in Beowulf's handling, a space for masculine pursuit and a textual object for the ironic representation of the sea of trouble that besets the Danish men and their ruler. Beowulf handles Unferth's isomorphic reference, aimed at exposing his recklessness, with a view to bringing up a forceful articulation of the crisis at Heorot. He also articulates the crisis as resulting from the lack of courage and heroism on the part of the Danes.

[59]As Price observes, "Beowulf's masculinity depends not only upon demon strations of his masculine prowess but also upon revealing the inferiority of other men —whether Breca or Unferð", "Sufficient Tragedy". 687.

Armoured Phenomenology and Grendel's Mother's Mere

As Nicole Guenther Discenza observes, Beowulf's cleansing of Heorot from Grendel restores the hall to its proper role.[60] However, Beowulf's defeat of Grendel displays a potential for another crisis. When Grendel, defeated and armless, enters the mere, its waters become another body of turbulent water in a provocative proximity to another crisis that is to beset the Danes:

ðær wæs on blode	brim weallende,
atol yða geswing	eal gemenged
haton heolfre,	heorodreore weol

> The water was seething and boiling with blood, the menacing rolling of waves, filled with hot gore, swelling with battle-dread (ll. 847-849).

The passage uses some of the vocabulary that Leslie Lockett finds typical of how the cardiocentric heat is evoked to characterise psychological distress in Old English verse.[61] While *weallande* and *weol* conventionally appear in descriptions of seething and swelling angry minds, they here indicate the turbulence of the mere's waters. Grendel, when approaching Heorot, is described as *gebolgen* (angry) (723b), and the verb *belgan* as well as the past participle *gebolgen* are, as Lockett indicates, strongly associated with such minds seething with the heat of anger. The waters of the mere are hot and, like Grendel's blood, poisonous.[62] It would appear that, as Grendel is dying in the mere, the place, conveniently placed at some distance from Heorot, receives his blood that sustained the heat of his anger when he was alive. Grendel's mother's surprise attack on Heorot causes Beowulf to dive into the waters of the mere, another account that renders a body of water another representational site for articulating masculine tensions and anxieties. The mere is imagined in the poem as a space connected to the sea, as the poetic sense of the Old English *mere* is the sea.[63] The apparent confusion of the fens and the sea in the poem validates Beowulf's accomplishment as a prodigious swimmer and invests his victory with symbolic significance. Most importantly, however, the passage develops a phenomenological masculine perspective on the environment, a symbolic gaze that Beowulf transfers through his gifts, which he brings from the mere to Hrothgar.

The account is also significantly inflected with the isomorphic language of emotion that merges Hrothgar's mind and Grendel's mother's mere. When Hrothgar expresses his sorrow caused by Æschere's death, he is *on hreon mode* (troubled/angry in his mind) (l. 1307b). As Gillian R. Overing remarks, the adjective *hreoh* may refer to moods and weather, meaning in different contexts "angry" or "stormy".[64] In the Breca episode, the word is applied to the weather's hostility. Hrothgar's mind thus seems to

[60]Discenza, *Inhabited Spaces,* 147.

[61]In her brief analysis of "The Ruin", in which thermal waters overflow the walls of the ruin, Leslie Locket argues that "for a reader who is aware of the psychological significance of heat and seething in the breast, this constellation of images – the seething liquid and the 'bosom' of the buildings – unmistakably evokes emotional distress", *Anglo-Saxon Psychologies*, 67.

[62]See Lockett, *Anglo-Saxon Psychologies*, especially 59, for the discussion of the use of verbs *weallan* and (*ge*)*belgan* in such contexts.

[63]Roberta Frank argues that the *Beowulf* poet uses the word in a poetic sense to suggest a seascape, while in Old English prose the word refers to fresh water, '"Mere" and "sund"', 154.

[64]Overing, "Men in Trouble", 30–31.

metaphorically internalise the violent storm of Grendel's mother's mere and the sea. In his edition of *Beowulf*, Klaeber glosses *hreoh* "rough, fierce, savage, troubled" and *hreohmod* as "troubled in mind, fierce". In his glossary, Klaeber suggests that the word is related to *blod-*, *guð-*, *wæl-reow* (2008: 399). In line 548a, Beowulf remembers the turbulent sea-waves that he and Breca had to contend with during their swimming match: *hreo wæron yþa* (waves were ferocious) (l. 548).

Hrothgar's own account of Grendel's mother merely supplies an image of an environment replete with objects and beings that are elementally transgressive as they transverse such dichotomies as land/water and ground/air.

warigeað, wulfhleoþu,
frecne fengelad,
under næssa genipu
flod under foldan.
milgemearces
ofer þæm hongiað
wudu wyrtum fæst
þær mæg nihta gehwæm
fyr on flode.
gumena bearna,
ðeah þe hæðstapa
heorot hornum trum,
feorran geflymed,
aldor on ofre,
hafelan hydan.
þonon yðgeblond
won to wolcnum,
lað gewidru,
roderas reotað

Hie dygel lond
windige næssas,
ðær fyrgenstream
niþer gewiteð,
Nis þæt feor heonon
þæt se mere standeð;
hrinde bearwas,
wæter oferhelmað.
niðwundor seon,
No þæs frod leofað
þæt þone grund wite;
hundum geswenced,
holtwudu sece,
ær he feorh seleð,
ær he in wille
Nis þæt heoru stow!
up astigeð
þonne wind styreþ,
oðþæt lyft ðrysmaþ,

> They inhabit a secret land, wolf-slopes and windy promontories, a dangerous passage across the fen, where a mountain-stream under the shadow of cliffs vanishes under the surface of the earth. It is not far from here in miles that the lake stands. Over the lake hang groves covered with frost, wood, whose roots are firm, are overwhelmed by water. There a night wonder is seen, fire in the water. No wise man lives who knows the place. Even when pursued by hounds, a stag, proud with antlers, seeks the wood put to flight, would sooner give up its life on the lake's shore than seek refuge and hide its head in its waters. This is not a pleasant place! Surging water rises to clouds when the wind blows during the inclement weather until they stifle the air and the sky weeps with rain (1357b-1376a).

The horrific place is a forest, but also a fen whose waters resemble sea-waves. The use of the word *mere* is also evocative of the sea, even though both Grendel and his mother are said to inhabit the fens and moors, and the word *fyrgenstream* is defined by the Toronto Old English Dictionary as "mountain-stream". The place is also characterised by inclement weather. Its waters are stormy and transgressive, termed *yðgeblond* (a mingling of waves) (l. 1373a) to suggest that they rise to the sky. His description might therefore seem a projection of his mental disturbance. In *The Heat of Beowulf,* Daniel C. Remein provides a detailed analysis of what he terms the deforming style that invigorates the passage. He reconsiders the compound *yðgeblond* in terms of the Old English poetic hydraulic model of the mind. As he points out, the verb *astigan,* used in the passage above to indicate that the movement of the disturbed waters is upwards, often appears

in cardiocentric descriptions of swollen minds.[65] Hrothgar's stormy anger and the reflection of Grendel's now subdued pride in the mere's surging water are thus mediated in the poem through phenomenological poetics of landscape, conflating mental states and physical locations.

Through such projections, the account of Beowulf's fight with Grendel's mother inspires an intense ecophobia.[66] Her abode is transformed, as its turbulent waters will eventually subside as Beowulf emerges victorious from them. The forest surrounding the mere and the mere's waters, for example, is imagined by Hrothgar as inhospitable. The phrase *wudu wyrtum fæst* (wood, whose roots are firm) (l.1364a) can sound menacing when Beowulf's sea-voyage is remembered. The wood from which Beowulf's ship is made is described as a flexible material, *wudu bundenne* (bound wood, a ship with a bound prow) (l. 216b). Here, around the mere, the wood is, however, *fæst* and unlikely to be capable of serving as construction material. Hrothgar's closing remark may, however, assuage to some extent the anxiety that this monstrous space inspires. He promises to reward Beowulf with *wundnum golde* (l. 1382a). The wound gold is a human-made object that symbolises human triumph over earth as a natural element: metal is made into an object by human hands, an object that is elaborate and intricate in shape. Beowulf's victory over Grendel's mother will thus not only satisfy Hrothgar's loss. It is also supposed to bear a representative force that will revise Hrothgar's perception of the hostile landscape that is not far from Heorot (l. 1361b-1362). Since the description is addressed to Beowulf, it sounds as if Beowulf was being teased and challenged by Hrothgar's description. His sea-crossing to the Danes (l. 207b-228) appeared to be an optimistic account of a successful territorialisation of the sea as a potentially hostile space.

In addition, the waters of the mere appear to be gendered, but their gendering suggests an imbalance that must be redressed on masculine terms. As Heide Estes and Nicole Guenther Discenza demonstrate, there is a strong connection between the waters of the mere and Grendel's mother's femininity. Both Heide Estes and Discenza describe the mere as a womb-like space. As Discenza puts it, "the infant Beowulf once emerged from a watery feminine space; now Beowulf must struggle in a second such space to survive and re-emerge".[67] She also observes that Grendel's Mother's hostility defies the expectations of a mother's nurturing role.[68] Estes bases her reading of the monstrous landscape in *Beowulf* on Julia Kristeva's investigation into the symbolism of menstrual blood, the mere being associated with menstruation and blood and represented as "a

[65]Remein, "The Heat of *Beowulf*, 162–3. "In instances in which the words *wylm* or *weallan* serve to mark disturbing or even disease-like affects within the Old English corpus, they often occur along the verb *astigan* (to go up, mount up, rise – in medical contexts, to spread), as here, "yðgeblond up astigeð' (wave-tossing mounts upwards)" 163. In light of Francis Leneghan's analysis of righteous anger in *Beowulf*, it might be said that if Beowulf's vengeful action represents divine justice, then his actions against Grendel's mother might be conceived of as punishing the violent inhabitants of the mere, "Beowulf, the Wrath of God", 394–5. For an authoritative account of the Old English poetic concepts of cardiocentric heat and the boiling mind, on which Remein's analysis rests, see Lockett, *Anglo-Saxon Psychologies*, especially 59–62.

[66]Remein's argument, regarding the use of nominal compounds in Hrothgar's description of the mere, emphasises the deformation of human discourse towards more-than-human poetics. He claims that in the description "under pressure, the aesthetic heat of these compound words is deforming and pressurising of both the poem and the human sensorium", *The Heat of Beowulf*, 163. My argument is, however, aligned with an ecocritical and ecofeminist hermeneutics of suspicion to uncover the anthropocentric gender imbalance in these representations.

[67]Discenza, *Inabited Spaces,* 149.

[68]Ibid.

kind of *vagina dentata*, monstrously fearsome in its geographical formulation, the toothy animals reaching out to grab Beowulf as he descends".[69] Beowulf's men are represented as killing Grendel's mother's other offspring. The beasts other than the Grendelkin inhabiting the mere are allegorical, ceasing to exist as Grendel's mother dies.[70] "Beowulf re-inscribes the space in which Grendel and his mother lived: once womb/dwelling, it is now a tomb".[71] Estes argues that Beowulf's emergence from the mere is "a re-birth from a feminized, liminal marsh, neither land nor sea, into a masculine social order".[72]

Beowulf dives into Grendel's Mother's mere in full armour, complete with a helmet and a sword.[73] It has often been argued that the poet's insistence on Beowulf's use of weapons in his combat with Grendel's mother reflects his larger design of representing each subsequent combat as more difficult than the earlier.[74] The number of military objects that Beowulf brings suggests that Grendel's mother is more dangerous than Grendel. Also, Beowulf defeats Grendel in one round. It will take two rounds of fighting to defeat his mother. The fight with Grendel's mother is, yet, not as dangerous as Beowulf's fight with the dragon in the second part. Beowulf dives into the mere as an assemblage of a human body and cultural objects metaphorically raised to the social status of his retainers.

	Gyrede hine Beowulf
eorlgewædum,	nalles for ealdre mearn.
Scolde herebyrne	hondum gebroden,
sid ond searofah,	sund cunnian,
seo ðe bancofan	beorgan cuþe,
þæt him hildegrap	hreþre ne mihte,
eorres inwitfeng,	aldre gesceþðan;
ac se hwita helm	hafelan werede,
se þe meregrundas	mengan scolde,
secan sundgebland	since geweorðad,
befongen freawrasnum,	swa hine fyrndagum
worhte wæpna smið,	wundrum teode,
besette swinlicum,	þæt hine syðþan no
brond ne beadomecas	bitan ne meahton

Beowulf braced himself, donning armour. He did not fear for his life. His shirt of mail, woven with hands, broad and elaborately decorated, was determined to explore the

[69]Estes, *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscapes*, 47.
[70]Ibid., 48.
[71]Ibid.
[72]Ibid.
[73]The subject presupposed in these passages is *weapnodman,* a compound which in Old English designates a man. The male child could be referred to with such compounds as *wæpnedbearn* or *wæpnedcild.* A comprehensive discussion of Old English vocabulary pertaining to male and female life-courses can be found in Izdebska, "Weapon-Boys and Once-Maidens". The word makes one appearance in *Beowulf* in the narrator's comparison of women's strength to that of 'wæpnedmen /þonne heoru bunden, hamere geþruen, /sweord swate fah swin ofer helme /ecgum dyhtig andweard scireð' [armoured men, when a bound sword, forged with hammers, stained with sweat, cuts asunder a boar decorating a helmet] (1284b–1287). The comparison is made to compare Grendel's mother's strength to the prowess of men she is to oppose at Heorot. While in prose and much of the Old English verse the word tends to function as a dead metaphor referring to men in general rather specifically to armoured warriors, in this passage from *Beowulf* the narrator seems to evoke the word's etymological meaning, its referent being exclusively fully armoured men. Fred C. Robinson explains that when the word appears in lines 1284–1287 the use of apposition results in "[exercising] in the audience's mind in noticing elemental meanings or words or in recalling etymological origins", "Two Aspects of Variation", 66. The passage may also be a form of prolepsis, as Beowulf will eventually approach Grendel's mother in his her mere in full armour.
[74]Orchard, *Pride and Prodigies,* 28–29.

> waters of the lake. It knew how to protect the bone-chamber of his body, so that a hostile grasp could not harm his heart and life, a malicious hold laid on him by the angry one. Indeed, the glittering helmet protected the head. The helmet stirred up the bottom of the lake and sought the commotion of water, decorated with treasure, enveloped with splendid bands that a long time ago a weapon smith wrought with wondrous skill, beset with ornamental boars, so that no swords could bite him (*Beowulf,* lines 1441b-1454).

Beowulf's body, *bancofa* (a bone-enclosure) (l. 1445a), is enclosed and protected by his military accoutrements. At first, the fragment presents Beowulf as a subject and things as objects or tools. He readies himself by donning his military gear. In addition, the narrator reports that his mail-shirt was made by a human hand (or, rather, a man's hand). However, the imagery that develops in these lines goes on to undercut this initial perception that Beowulf is the agent of his actions, a perception that might imply that the weapons he is carrying are mere extensions of his body and act at his will. As Gillian R. Overing points out, military objects function as "the entire warrior apparatus that comprises armour, [and] are also integrally connected to bodies, and to the process of masculine embodiment in particular".[75] Overing observes that as each element comprising Beowulf's military gear "displays a life and will of its own", it also seems "imbued with the capacity to think independently about its function, and even possesses a degree of interiority".[76] As James Paz points out, in this fragment, "Beowulf draws each aspect of his fortitude from the external things he is putting on".[77] The *Beowulf* poet thus again suspends human agency at a critical moment to highlight the agency of objects. The locus of experience and action is distributed among human and nonhuman bodies.

Overing and Paz's new materialist readings demonstrate that the representation of Beowulf's body and his weapons as one flesh or an assemblage is a moment of inclusion that creates an intimacy between the human and nonhuman.[78] Admittedly, it is the armour that figuratively perceives the hostile environment. Beowulf's armoured body's investigative and penetrative agency produces a representation of the mere as an object of anthropocentric and androcentric perception and action. Beowulf's more-than-human body is not unlike that of a cyborg. In their provocative reading of the episode, Asa Simon Mittman and Patricia MacCormack claim that adorning the warrior with military equipment creates a new being:

> [the weapons] are both worn and wielded, carried and utilized *as* the subject of the warrior, and so they create an intimacy with the body akin to fleshly extension and thus subject modification, creating an emergent new warrior through bodily adornment.[79]

However, when reconsidered not from a new materialist, but from an ecofeminist perspective, the passage does not present a new being independent of human, and pervasively androcentric values. On the contrary, the complex assemblage of Beowulf's body and objects becomes an apparatus that operates upon nature as an object. More precisely,

[75]Overing, "*Beowulf*, A Poem in our Time", 323.
[76]Ibid., 325.
[77]Paz, "*Beowulf* as Weyland's Work", 81.
[78]Dana Oswald utilised the concept of assemblage, predicated upon Deleuze and Guattari's concept of becoming, to discuss the combat between Beowulf and Grendel, *Monsters, Gender, Sexuality,* 87–88. She evokes the example of the knight and the rider that Cohen develops to elucidate the assemblage formed by Beowulf and Grendel's bodies, *Monsters,* 87. See Cohen discussion of the knight and his horse an assemblage, *Medieval Identity Machines*, xxiii.
[79]Mittman and MacCormack, "Rebuilding the Fabulated Bodies", 358.

the environment of the mere is transformed into an object of masculine penetration. The emergent assemblage of the human self and material objects is a rhetorical device that perpetuates masculine heroic values, as well as informing the poem's masculinist exploration narrative.

As a pre-modern text, *Beowulf* offers a pre-Cartesian understanding of an embodied and materially embedded subject. However, as an epic poem imbued with an ambition to represent the materialist values of its readers' class and rank, it also inculcates their ideological perception of landscape and the environment. The poem presupposes a dominant masculine perspective that embeds Beowulf in a manmade apparatus. From an eco-critical point of view, the representation of Beowulf's body and manmade objects is a symbolic site of exclusion. As both Beowulf and objects appear as subjects within this material assemblage, the passage presents a phenomenology of an armed and armoured body. The account renders the environment an object of masculine gaze and violation, mediating the environment through an androcentric representation. The mere becomes an object of masculine perception and representation, in addition to being a setting for masculine action and agency.

The narrative also supplies a man-centred revision of Grendel's Mother. Of course, Grendel's mother is not entirely denied subjectivity in the poem. On the contrary, when she is first described in the poem, she is depicted as a grieving mother who seeks revenge for her son's death.[80] She is also described as a noble woman, *ides aglæcwif* (noble female adversary)(l. 1259) and queen owning a hall.[81] This dignified characterisation of Grendel's mother is reinforced by the statement of her ownership of the place. As Fabienne Michelet puts it, "to occupy, to delimit, to defend [land]: this is precisely what is at stake in *Beowulf*", and this triad of functions is mostly ascribed to kings in *Beowulf*. Secondly, her actions can be identified as masculine, in that her attempts to penetrate Beowulf's body also construct a masculine gender for her, or at least blur a boundary between male heroic behaviour and the queen's role of a host, who peacefully receives her guests of honour in the hall.[82] Indeed, Grendel's mother might be said to be represented as king rather than queen in the poem. Notably, the narrator misgenders her with a masculine pronoun (*se,* instead of *seo,* is used at line 1497b), partly eliding Grendel's mother's femininity. M. Wendy Hennequin studies the overlap between the use of *heoldan* in *Beowulf* and the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* to argue that "Grendel's mother is not constructed along the lines of queens, but of kings".[83]

The account of Beowulf's fight with Grendel's mother juxtaposes his weaponised body with her body that becomes weaponised through its monstrous transspecies features. Most importantly, Grendel's mother's body is resilient to the Beowulfian embodied

[80]Jane Chance argues that Grendel's mother represents an inversion of the heroic ideal of *ides*, a noble woman, especially a monstrous inversion of Wealhtheow, who represents an ideal of peace-weaver, *The Woman as Hero*, 97.

[81]As Kathryn Hume claims, Grendel and his mother's dwelling has many features of a typical hall. "It is a *hof, niðsele, hofsele, reced*; it has a *flet,* treasure and walls hung with weapons. In harmony with this style of dwelling, Grendel's mother is an *ides* as well as an *aglæcwif*", "The Concept of the Hall", 68. The vocabulary used in *Beowulf* to refer to her rule over the mere parallels the vocabulary referencing kingship in *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle.* See Hennequin, "We've Created a Monster", for this argument

[82]Dana Oswald reads Beowulf and Grendel's mother combat as sexualised, with Grendel's mother on top of Beowulf, *Monsters, Gender, and Sexuality,* 95. Mary Dockray-Miller argues that Modthryth and Grendel's Mother construct a masculine identity for themselves, *Motherhood,* 88–89. On the masculinisation of Grendel's mother see Dockray-Miller, *Motherhood and Mothering in Anglo-Saxon England*, 95; Oswald, *Monsters, Gender, and Sexuality,* 95–96.

[83]Hennequin, "We've Created a Monaster", 511.

and militarily equipped apparatus both literally and symbolically. As Megan Cavell puts it, Grendel's and Grendel's mother's bodies incorporate embodied weapons. Cavell, in her seminal discussion of monstrous bodies in *Beowulf,* claims that both Grendel and Grendel's Mother instil horror as hybrids that "blur the line between body and object' and that "embody the precious objects of armour and weaponry".[84] As Cavell observes,

> what makes these bodies monstrous is precisely their uncanny resemblance to and simultaneous difference from the human body … Because constructed objects like armour are symbols of civilisation, their monstrous embodiment sets the monsters apart from both the world of culture and nature.[85]

Hrunting, Unferth's sword that Beowulf holds, cannot penetrate her and fails. While Beowulf's cumbersome war-gear provides ample protection against the inhabitants of the mere, Grendel's mother attacks (*gescod*, 1502b) him with *atolan clommum* (terrifying claws) (l. 1502a) and *laþan fingrum* (hostile fingers) (l. 1505b). Despite her efforts, she does not succeed in wounding and disabling Beowulf's *halan lice* (unhurt body) (l. 1503a).

While Beowulf's body is equipped with metal objects to resist penetration and dismemberment, Grendel's mother's body is thus weaponised in the sense that her skin and bones have the resilience of manmade armour.

Ongeat þa se goda	grundwyrgenne,
merewif mihtig;	mægenræs forgeaf
hildebille,	hond sweng ne ofteah,
þæt hire on hafelan	hringmæl agol
grædig guðleoð.	ða se gist onfand
þæt se beadoleoma	bitan nolde,
aldre sceþðan,	ac seo ecg geswac
ðeodne æt þearfe;	ðolode ær fela
hondgemota,	helm oft gescær,
fæges fyrdhrægl;	ða wæs forma sið
deorum madme,	þæt his dom alæg.

> The hero perceived the mighty sea-woman, the female creature of the deep. He gave a powerful thrust with his battle-sword, his arm did not withhold strength. On her head the sword sang a greedy heroic lay. The guest found that the shining sword would not bite and harm her life. The sword failed the lord in need; it had suffered through many combats, cutting through the helmets and armour of those destined to die. It was the first time that the glory of the dear treasure had waned (ll. 1518-1528)

The sword hitting Grendel's mother's head resounds, as it were, with a voracious war-song, and yet it cannot bite through her skin and skull. The metaphorical song creates for a moment a single phenomenal field for Beowulf and Grendel's mother, who share the same aural experience. In fact, her agency and subjectivity become the dominant force in this phenomenological horizon, as she is able to overpower and neutralise Beowulf's gaze and senses. His sword becomes weak and useless, and Beowulf casts it away. The personified sword is described as having weakened (*geswac*, l. 1524b). During her combat with Beowulf, Grendel's mother appears dangerous because she appears to

[84]Cavell, "Constructing the Monstrous Body," 158.
[85]Ibid., 163.

refuse to be subsumed into Beowulf's masculine phenomenal field as an object. In fact, the text creates a phenomenological horizon for Grendel's mother, from which she returns the Beowulfian gaze and strikes back. In the phenomenal field of the mere, Grendel's mother is a subject and agent too, and, increasingly, her cognition, embodiment and physical violence become a dominating presence, making a strong impression on Beowulf's senses and embodied experience.

Benjamin A. Salzman has recently explored the significance of song in *Beowulf* for its ambiguous potential to create networks of both intimacy and exclusion[86] (2020: 32–34). In his discussion of the poem, he mostly focuses on Grendel. While Grendel's is excluded from the aural community of Heorot, Grendel's mother's body is able to interact with the sword Hrunting, a personified representative of Heorot's community,[87] and create a song that overpowers both the sword and Beowulf's arm. Eventually, Beowulf defeats Grendel's mother by means of a giant sword, whose hilt carries an inscribed account of the biblical flood. Beowulf not only defeats her but also neutralises her by having Grendel's mother disappear from the ensuing narrative.[88]

Instead of presenting Grendel's mother's body that posed a serious threat to him, Beowulf brings from the mere Grendel's head, which he severed from his body with the sword that he also used to overcome Grendel's mother. He thus objectifies the body of Grendel and commodifies it into a gift presented to the Danes. Grendel's mother's body, however, never materialises as an object to look at and interpret. Dana Oswald, in her discussion of monstrous bodies in *Beowulf,* claims that in his account of the fight with Grendel's mother delivered later to Hygelac, Beowulf replaces Grendel's mother's body with that of her son, leading to her erasure from the narrative of the combat with the Grendelkin,[89] In addition, both Grendel's body and his mother's body are dehumanised, to use Rosi Braidotti's formulation, "the sexualised, racialised, and naturalised others, who reduced to the less than human status of disposable bodies".[90] Grendel's mother's subjectivity is thus revised and eventually excised from the poem's malestream perspective. Grendel's mother's identity is overshadowed by the narrator's investment in her role as Beowulf's worthy opponent to be finally excised from the narrative. Her body exists in the narrative insofar as it serves the interests of the masculine embodiment.

In addition, Grendel's mother becomes a resource for masculine exploitation both literally and symbolically. While most of the treasure that lies in the hall is not plundered by Beowulf, his act of plundering includes the carrying away of Grendel's head and the hilt of the giant sword, two trophies which he identifies as *sælac* (sea-booty) (l. 1652a). These gifts shape the perception of space that Beowulf invaded and plundered, contributing to the role Grendel's mother's mere presence plays in the ideological representation of the landscape that the Danes will hold on to.

[86]Salzman, "Community, Joy, and Intimacy", 32–34.
[87]In lines 1455–64, the sword is personified as a friend and companion.
[88]Oswald, *Monsters, Gender, Sexuality*, especially 107–9.
[89]*Monsters, Gender, Sexuality*, 106.
[90]Braidotti, *The Posthuman,* 15. It is notable that the *Beowulf* poet remarks that the Danes do not care for Grendel's life when Grendel escapes from Heorot to die in the mere: "ne his lif-dagas leoda ængum /nytte tealde" [no one among the nation cared for is life and counted his days as meaningful] (793–794a). The phrasing seems to be underscored by a notion that Grendel is attributed some subhuman status by the Danes.

Beowulf's Sea-Booty

Before he comes back from the mere with gifts, however, an interesting moment generating much suspense over the outcome of Beowulf's expedition takes place when the Danes give up their hope that Beowulf might emerge alive from the mere and return to Heorot. The Geats, however, remain and wait. Is it a moment of relief for Hrothgar and the Danes? Would not the Geats take over the burden of responsibility for avenging Beowulf, a feat they would not accomplish and become as helpless as the Danish heroes are now, themselves unable to avenge Æscere's death? Beowulf's climactic emergence from the waters is a moment that invests him with political agency and a measure of symbolic power over Hrothgar and the Danes. If representations of triumphs over nature are conceived of in terms of currency in the exchange of honour that assigns status and validates rank among men, Beowulf will be the dispenser of pleasure that can be derived from his account of Grendel's mother's defeat and his successful probing of the depths of the mere. Beowulf's representational powers derived from his objectification of hostile landscapes, sea depths, and monstrous lakes generate anxiety in the Danes and in Hrothgar. Beowulf's success posits him as the major agent in the environment projected as a masculine discursive formation.

This anxiety is wisely resolved by Beowulf, who bestows the hilt on Hrothgar as *sæ-lac* (sea-booty) (l. 1652a), an important gesture that confirms Hrothgar's reputation as the greatest king *be sæm tweonum* (between the two seas) (l. 1685b). Beowulf's own words and the poet's description of his gesture stabilise the symbolism of the sea as a referent for Hrothgar's rule. While Hrothgar cannot validate his power in battle, Beowulf's gesture constructs the king as a masculine subject who exercises authority through gaze. The scene counterbalances the earlier moment of Grendel's mother's sensual and aural domination within the mere.

Hwæt! we þe þas sælac, sunu Healfdenes,
leod Scyldinga, lustum brohton
tires to tacne, þe þu her to locast

Listen! We have brought you sea-booty, the son of Healfdene, man of the Scyldings, with joy as a sign of glory, so that you can look at it (ll. 1652-1654).

Beowulf expressly identifies the sea as the source of the gift, aligning the mere with the sea rather than the fens. The gift is also transferred to Hrothgar, becoming the token of his rule. The exclamatory *Hwæt* (listen!) (l. 1652) directs the assembled women and men's attention to the gifts and Hrothgar's as their recipient. The centre of the phenomenal field becomes, however, ultimately, located in Hrothgar's gaze. Hrothgar's gaze embodies the perspective through which the story of the hilt is mediated. While readers of *Beowulf* questioned the extent to which the Danish pagan ruler can understand the biblical account of the flood, the early medieval English Christian audience participates in the gaze, aligning that which the king actually sees with the narratorial Christian account of the flood as a destruction of monstrous races.

Hroðgar maðelode; hylt sceawode,
ealde lafe. On ðæm wæs or writen
fyrngewinnes; syðþan flod ofsloh,
gifen geotende, giganta cyn,

frecne geferdon; þæt wæs fremde þeod
ecean dryhtne; him þæs endelean
þurh wæteres wylm waldend sealed

> Hrothgar spoke, looking at the hild, an ancient inheritance, on which the origin of an ancient strife was described/engraved. The flood killed a tribe of giants, the surging ocean. They suffered terribly. That tribe was strange to the eternal God. The lord gave them retribution by means of the surging of water (ll. 1687-1693).

The biblical flood, referred to as *flod* (flood) (l. 1689b) and *wæteres wylm* (seething of water) (l. 1693), becomes in the account the instrument of divine retribution, a token of divine power. God's control of landscape and the environment emerges as a symbol of ultimate power. The simplex *wylm*, a word appearing in compounds that denote emotions of sorrow and helplessness but also anger, might be an index of God's retributive wrath visited on sinful giants.[91] Hrothgar's gaze validates the malestream view of the mere from a Christian and patristic perspective, a perspective that is supplied by the authoritative voice of the Christian narrator.

Conclusions: *Beowulf's* Armed and Armoured Phenomenology of Space

Recent discussions of the human and nonhuman world in Old English literature emphasise the intimacy between both.[92] This article by no means discourages readers of *Beowulf* from exploring the poem as ecopoetry. What this paper argues is that representations of the isomorphism of the human and non-human world are not free from textual violence and anthropocentric ideology. I would conclude that the analysis presented in this article comports well with Alfred K. Siewers's argument that representations of landscape in *Beowulf* (and *Guthlac A*) reflect the Western acquisitiveness for the environment as a standing reserve, replete with resources both for consumption and an instrument for exercising power and domination.[93] Men in *Beowulf*, I have argued here, adduce representations of the environment to create and resolve crises of masculine identity, power and domination. The narrator also uses ambivalent imagery of welling and surging to represent men in power. Both the physical environment and its representation are symbolic sites for the construction of authority and domination in the poem.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

ORCID

Jacek Olesiejko http://orcid.org/0000-0002-7047-2498

[91]For an argument that Beowulf's anger is "the manifestation of the wrath of God" aroused by Grendel's evil see Leneghan, "Beowulf, The Wrath of God", especially 392.
[92]See especially Dale, *The Natural World in the Exeter Book Riddles*, especially 20–25; Soper, *Life-Course*, especially 12–14, where she interrogates the concepts of anthropomorphism and isomorphism.
[93]Siewers, *Landscapes of Conversion*.

References

Abram, Christopher. "At Home in the Fens with the Grendelkin." In *Dating Beowulf: Studies in Intimacy*, edited by Daniel C. Remein, and Erica Weaver, 120–144. Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020.

Andrews, Tarren. "Research, Renewal, and Radical Compassion: Thoughts on an Indigenous Feminist Reading of the 'Wife's Lament'." *IONA, Medieval Sovereignties*, 1-13.

Cameron Angus, et al. *Dictionary of Old English: A to Le*. https://indiv.dictionary.doe.utoronto.ca/doe/.

Barajas, Coutrney Catherine. *Old English Ecotheology: The Exeter Book*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2021.

Benson, Larry. "The Originality of *Beowulf*." In *The Interpretation of Narrative: Theory and Practice*, edited by Morton W. Bloomfield, 1–43. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970.

Bjork, Robert E. *Old English Shorter Poems. Vol. II: Wisdom and Lyric*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2014.

Bloomfield, Josephine. "Diminished by Kindness: Frederick Klaeber's Rewriting of Wealhtheow." *The Journal of English and Germanic Philology* 93, no. 2 (1994): 183–203.

Braidotti, Rosi. *The Posthuman*. Cambridge: Polity Press, 2013.

———. *2022 Posthuman Feminism*. Cambridge: Polity Press, 2020.

Brodeur, Arthur Gilchrist. *The Art of Beowulf*. Berkeley and London: University of California Press, 1971.

Bryson, J. Scott, ed. *Ecopoetry: A Critical Introduction*. Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 2002.

Buchanan, Peter. "Phenomenal Anglo-Saxons: Perception, Adaptation, and the Poetic Imagination" (PhD dissertation, University of Toronto, 2013).

Cavell, Megan. "Constructing the Monstrous Body in *Beowulf*." *Anglo-Saxon England* 43 (2014): 155–181.

Chance, Jane. *Woman as Hero in Old English Literature*. Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 1986.

Clemoes, Peter. "Action in *Beowulf* and Our Perception of it." In *Old English Poetry: Essays on Style*, edited by Daniel G. Calder, 147–168. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1979.

Clover, Carol J. "The Germanic Context of the Unferþ Episode." In *The Beowulf Reader*, edited by Peter S. Baker, 127–154. New York: Routledge, 2000.

Cohen, Jeffery Jerome. *Medieval Identity Machines*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2003.

Conrad O'Brian, Helen. "Listen to the Woman: Reading Wealhtheow as Stateswoman." In *New Readings on Women and Early Medieval English Literature*, edited by Helene Scheck, and Christine E. Kozikowski, 191–208. Leeds: Arc Humanities Press, 2019.

Dale, Corinne. *The Natural World in the Exeter Book Riddles*. Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2017.

Discenza, Nicole Guenther. *Inhabited Spaces: Anglo-Saxon Constructions of Space*. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2017.

Du Bois, Arthur E. "The Unity of Beowulf." *Publication of the Modern Language Assciation* 49 (1934): 374–405.

Eliason, Norman E. "The þyle and scop in *Beowulf*." *Speculum* 38, no. 2 (1963): 267–284.

Enright, Michael J. "The Warband Context of the Unferth Episode." *Speculum* 73, no. 2 (1998): 297–337.

Estes, Heide. *Anglo-Saxon Literary Landscape: Ecotheory and Environmental Imagination*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2017.

——— "Boundaries Embodied: An Ecofeminist Reading of the Old English *Judith*." In *New readings on women and early medieval English literature*, edited by Helene Scheck, and Christine E. Kozikowski, 179–190. Leeds: Arc Humanities Press, 2019.

Frank, Roberta. "'Mere' and 'Sund': Two Sea Changes in Old English Literature." In *Modes and Interpretations in Old English Literature: Essays in Honour of Stanley B. Greenfield*, edited by

Phyllis Rugg Brown, Georgia Ronan Crampton, and Fred C. Robison, 153–172. Toronto: Toronto University Press, 1986.
Gaard, Greta. *Critical Ecofeminism*. Lanham: Lexington Books, 2017.
Haraway, Donna J. *Staying with the Trouble: Making the Chthulucene*. Durham: Duke University Press, 2016.
Hennequin, M. Wendy. "We′ve Created a Monster: The Strange Case of Grendel′s Mother." *English Studies* 89, no. 5 (2008): 503–523.
Howe, Nicholas. *Migration and Mythmaking in Anglo-Saxon England*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1989.
Hultman, Martin and Paul M. Pulé, eds. *Ecological Masculinities: Theoretical Foundations and Practical Guidance*. London: Routledge, 2018.
———, eds. *Men, Masculinities, and Earth*. Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2021.
Hume, Kathryn. "The concept of the hall in Old English poetry." *Anglo-Saxon England* 3 (1974): 63–74.
Izdebska, Daria. "Weapon-boys and Once-Maidens: A Study of Old English Vocabulary for Stages of Life." In *Early Medieval English Life Course: Cultural-Historical Perspective*, edited by Thijs Porck, and Harriet Soper, 47–89. Leiden: Brill, 2022.
Kheel, Marti. *Nature Ethics: An Ecofeminist Perspective*. Lanham: Rowman &Littlefield, 2009.
Kim, Dorothy. "The Question of Race in *Beowulf*." *JSTOR Daily*, September 25, 2019.: https://daily.jstor.org/the-question-of-race-in-beowulf/.
Klaeber's Beowulf, ed. by Fulk, R. D, Robert E. Bjork & John D. Niles (The fourth edition.) (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2008).
Leneghan, Francis. *The Dynastic Drama of Beowulf*. Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2020.
Leneghan, Francis. "*Beowulf*: The Wrath of God, and the Fall of the Angels." *English Studies* 105, no. 3 (2024): 383–403.
Lockett, Leslie. *Anglo-Saxon Psychologies in the Vernacular and Latin Traditions*. Toronto: Toronto University Press, 2011.
Low, Matt. "′Heard Gripe Hrusan′ (the Hard Grip of the Earth): Ecopoetry and the Anglo-Saxon Elegy." *Mosaic* 42 (2009): 1–18.
Magennis, Hugh. *Images of Community in Old English Poetry*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996.
Merchant, Carolyn. *The Death of Nature: Women, Ecology, and the Scientific Revolution*. New York: HarperOne.
Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Phenomenology of Perception*. Translated by Donald A. Landes. London: Routledge.
Michelet, Fabienne L. *Creation, Migration, Conquest: Imaginary Geography and Sense of Space in Old English Literature*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006.
Mittman, Asa Simon, and Patricia MacCormack. "Rebuilding the Fabulated Bodies of the Hoard-Warriors." *Postmedieval: A Journal of Medieval Cultural Studies* 7, no. 3 (2016): 356–368.
Morrison, Toni. "Grendel and his Mother." In *The Source of Self-Regard: Selected Essays, Speeches, and Meditation*, edited by Toni Morrison, 255–262. New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 2019.
Neidorf, Leonard. "Unferth′s Ambiguity and the Trivialisation of Germanic Legend." *Neophilologus* 101, no. 3 (2017): 439–454.
Neidorf, Leonard. "On *Beowulf* and the *Nibelungslied*: Counselors, Queens, and Characterisation." *Neohelicon* 47, no. 2 (2020): 655–672.
Neville, Jennifer. *Representations of the Natural in Old English Poetry*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999.
O′Brien, Mary. *The Politics of Reproduction*. Boston: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1981.
Olesiejko, Jacek. "The Grendelkin and the Politics of Succession at Heorot: The Significance of the Monsters in *Beowulf*." *Studia Anglica Posnaniensia* 53 (2018): 45–65.
Orchard, Andy. *Pride and Prodigies: Studies in the Monsters of the Beowulf-Manuscript*. Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 1995.
Oswald, Dana M. *Monsters, Gender and Sexuality in Medieval English literature*. Woodbridge: D. S. Brewer, 2010.

Overing, Gillian R. "*Beowulf*: A poem in our time." In *The Cambridge History of Early Medieval English Literature*, edited by Clare A. Lees, 309–331. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013.

Overing, Gillian R. "Men in Trouble." In *Rivalrous Masculinities: New Directions in Medieval Gender Studies*, edited by Ann Marie Rasmussen, 27–41. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 2019.

Paz, James. "Beowulf as Wayland's Work: Thinking, Feeling, Making." In *Dating Beowulf: Studies in Intimacy*, edited by Daniel C. Remein, and Erica Weaver, 73–94. Manchester: Manchester University Press.

Plumwood, Val. *Feminism and the Mastery of Nature*. London: Routledge, 1993.

Plumwood, Val. *Environmental Culture: The Ecological Crisis of Reason*. London: Routledge.

Price, Basil Arnould. "Sufficient tragedy: Masculinity as cruel optimism in *Beowulf*." *English Studies* 105, no. 5 (2024): 681–702.

Remein, Daniel C. *The Heat of Beowulf*. Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2022.

Robinson, Fred C. "Elements of the Marvellous in the Characterisation of Beowulf: A Reconsideration of Textual Evidence." In *The Beowulf Reader*, edited by Peter S. Baker, 79–96. London: Routledge.

——— "Two Aspects of Variation in Old English Poetry." In *Old English Poetry: Essays on Style*, edited by Daniel G. Calder, 127–145. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1979.

———. *Beowulf and the Appositive Style*. Knoxville: The University of Tennessee Press, 1985.

Saltzman, Benjamin A. "Community, Joy, and the Intimacy of Narrative in *Beowulf*." In *Dating Beowulf: Studies in intimacy*, edited by Daniel C. Remein, and Erica Weaver, 31–53. Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020.

Siewers, Alfred K. "Landscapes of Conversion: Guthlac's Mound and Grendel's Mere as Expressions of Anglo-Saxon Nation Building." In *The Postmodern Beowulf: A Critical Casebook*, edited by Eileen A. Joy, and Mary K. Ramsey, 199–257. Morgantown: Western Virginia University Press, 2006.

Soper, Harriet. *The Life-Course in Old English Poetry*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2024.